Think Like a Hacker: Speaker Script

MCCJ 525 | 10-minute group presentation | 5 members × 2 slides × ~1 minute each

Tips: *Text in [square brackets] is a stage cue, not something to say aloud. Each section is about 150 words, roughly one minute at a calm pace. Practise once with a timer.*

MEMBER 1 – [Your Name]

Slide 1: Title: Think Like a Hacker (about 1 minute)

[Start by looking around the room slowly.]

Imagine, for the next ten minutes, that you are not a student. You are a cybercriminal. You are sitting in a small room with a laptop, and every account in this room is a possible target.

Which one would you go after first? The one with the most money? The most followers? No. You would go after the easiest one.

Good morning. We are Group [__], and our presentation is called "Think Like a Hacker." To understand how secure Facebook, Instagram, WhatsApp, Gmail and Telegram really are, we decided to look at them the way an offender does: not "what features does this app have?", but "what stands between me and this account?"

As criminology students, we have a theory for exactly this question. Let me show you.

Slide 2: The theory: crime happens when three things meet (about 1 minute)

This is Routine Activity Theory, from Cohen and Felson, 1979. It says a crime happens when three things meet: *[point to each corner]* a motivated offender, a suitable target, and the absence of a capable guardian.

Online, the offenders are scammers, hackers and extortionists. The targets are us: around 64 million Bangladeshis on Facebook alone.

[Right side.] The numbers prove it. In the Cyber Crime Awareness Foundation's 2024 study, account hacking was the number one cybercrime, affecting 21.65 percent of victims. 78.78 percent of victims were aged 18 to 30. And only 12 percent reported it to the police.

Here is the key idea of our presentation. We cannot remove the offenders, and we cannot stop being targets. The one corner we control is the guardian: the security features on our accounts, and whether we switch them on.

So in this presentation, we measure each platform's guardians. [Member 2] will explain how.

MEMBER 2 – [Your Name]

Slide 3: The offender's checklist: five questions (about 1 minute)

Thank you, [Member 1]. So how does a hacker decide which account to attack? We believe they ask five questions. *[Read the red questions in a hacker's voice.]*

"Can I get in with just a stolen password?"

"Can the messages be read on the company's servers?"

"Will the owner be warned that I'm in?"

"Can I lock the real owner out?"

"Can I find and message the victim?"

[Point to the blue column.] Each question is answered by a guardian: login protection, encryption by default, threat alerts, recovery safety and privacy controls. We scored each guardian from 1 to 5, so the strongest possible platform scores 25.

We gathered the evidence from the security settings on our own accounts, and checked it against official help pages and recent news.

And instead of going alphabetically, we will go the way a hacker would: from the softest target to the hardest. The softest target, surprisingly, is Telegram.

Slide 4: Target 1 – Telegram: the softest target of the five (about 1 minute)

[Switch into "hacker voice" for the red quote.] "Most chats aren't end-to-end encrypted, and few users ever set a cloud password. I join their groups and wait."

[Normal voice.] Target one: Telegram. Guardian strength: 14 out of 25, the softest target.

Many students think Telegram is the most private app. But only "Secret Chats" are end-to-end encrypted, and you must start them manually. Ordinary chats, groups and channels are stored on Telegram's servers. And since September 2024, Telegram says it will share the IP addresses and phone numbers of rule-breakers with authorities on valid legal requests.

[Middle column.] The guardians do exist: a two-step cloud password, a passcode lock, active-session control, and the option to hide your phone number.

[Blue card.] The guardian we would add: end-to-end encryption by default for one-to-one chats, and a prompt to set up two-step verification at sign-up.

[Member 3] takes the next target.

MEMBER 3 – [Your Name]

Slide 5: Target 2 – Facebook: strong locks, but the back door is recovery (about 1 minute)

[Hacker voice.] "I phish the password with a fake copyright violation notice, then swap the recovery email and phone before the owner wakes up."

[Normal voice.] Target two: Facebook. Guardian strength: 16 out of 25.

Facebook's front door is well guarded: two-factor authentication through an app, SMS or a security key, login alerts, remote log-out, passkeys since June 2025, profile lock, and Messenger chats encrypted by default.

[Red weak spot.] But the back door is recovery. Once a hacker is in, they can change the recovery email and phone number within minutes, while the real owner waits days or weeks to get the account back. Recovery safety scored just 2 out of 5. *[Point to the meter.]*

[Blue card.] The guardian we would add: a 48-hour cool-down before recovery details can change, alerts to the old email and phone, and real human support in Bangla.

Slide 6: Target 3 – Instagram: once inside, the DMs are an open book (about 1 minute)

[Hacker voice.] "I get in through linked Meta accounts and read the DMs. They aren't end-to-end encrypted, so private photos become my leverage."

[Normal voice.] Target three: Instagram. Guardian strength: 16 out of 25.

That quote describes how sextortion often begins. Instagram DMs were never end-to-end encrypted by default, and on 8 May 2026 Meta removed even the optional encrypted chats. On encryption, Instagram scored just 1 out of 5. *[Point to the meter.]*

[Middle column.] The other guardians are decent: Meta's two-factor authentication and login alerts, Restrict and Hidden Words against harassment, private-by-default Teen Accounts, and a clever one: "Emails from Instagram", which lists every real security email from the last 14 days, so you can expose a fake one.

[Blue card.] The guardian we would add: restore encrypted DMs as the default, and blur unsolicited explicit images for every user, not just teenagers.

[Member 4] will take the two hardest targets.

MEMBER 4 – [Your Name]

Slide 7: Target 4 – Gmail: the prize every hacker wants, and the hardest to steal (about 1 minute)

Thank you, [Member 3]. *[Hacker voice.]* "Gmail is the master key: every reset link lands here. But with a passkey, there is no password for me to phish."

[Normal voice.] Target four: Gmail. Guardian strength: 20 out of 25, joint highest.

Think about it: when you click "forgot password" on Facebook, Instagram or even bKash, where does the link go? Your email. That is why hackers want Gmail most.

[Middle column.] And that is why Google guards it so heavily: passkeys as the default sign-in since October 2023, 2-Step Verification, a Security Checkup, critical sign-in alerts, and filters that Google says block over 99.9 percent of phishing and malware.

[Red weak spot.] The weak spot is us: people who reuse passwords and never switch on 2-Step Verification. Also, personal Gmail is not end-to-end encrypted.

[Blue card.] We would add optional end-to-end encryption, and warnings for emails imitating bKash, Nagad or local banks.

Slide 8: Target 5 – WhatsApp: the hardest target, so hackers attack the person (about 1 minute)

[Hacker voice.] "I can't break the encryption, so I break the person: I sent my code to you by mistake, please forward it."

[Normal voice.] Target five: WhatsApp, the hardest target. Guardian strength: 20 out of 25.

Every personal chat and call on WhatsApp is end-to-end encrypted by default; not even WhatsApp can read them. It has a six-digit two-step PIN, passkeys, passkey-locked backups since October 2025, and since January 2026, Strict Account Settings, a one-tap lockdown.

[Red weak spot.] So hackers don't attack the technology. They attack the human. Many of us have seen this exact message. Without a two-step PIN, one shared code hands over the whole account.

[Blue card.] The guardian we would add: a clear Bangla warning whenever a registration code is requested, and a mandatory two-step PIN.

[Member 5] will now give the hacker's final verdict.

MEMBER 5 – [Your Name]

Slide 9: The hacker's verdict: WhatsApp is the most secure for you (about 1 minute)

Thank you, [Member 4]. So, if you were the hacker, which account would you go after? *[Point left to right.]*

Telegram is the softest target at 14. Facebook and Instagram follow at 16. Gmail and WhatsApp are the hardest, both at 20.

Our verdict: WhatsApp is the most secure platform for an individual user. Not because it has the most features, but because its strongest guardian, end-to-end encryption, is switched on from day one. You don't need to do anything. That matters, because most people never open their settings.

Gmail is the prize every hacker wants, because it is the master key to every other account. Protect it with a passkey or 2-Step Verification.

And Telegram teaches us that a reputation for privacy is not the same as privacy by default.

But notice what the hacker did on almost every slide: they didn't break the technology. They went around it, through a weak password, a shared code, or a setting that was never switched on.

Slide 10: Be the capable guardian: make yourself the target hackers skip (about 1 minute)

Remember the triangle from Routine Activity Theory? Offender, target, guardian. We cannot remove the offenders. We cannot stop being targets. But each of us can become a capable guardian, tonight, in five minutes. *[Go through the cards.]*

One: turn on two-factor authentication or a passkey everywhere, and stolen passwords stop working.

Two: set a WhatsApp two-step PIN, and the code scam fails.

Three: never share an OTP with anyone. Not a friend, not "Facebook support", not "bKash".

Four: check your recovery email and phone, so no one can take over silently.

Five: log out of devices you don't recognise.

[Pause. Read the last line slowly.] Hackers look for the easiest target. Don't be it.

Thank you. We are happy to take your questions.